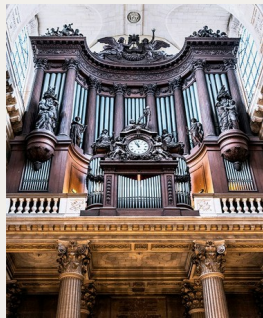


IN PROFILE

Aristide Cavaillé-Coll

Franck's contribution to the revival of organ music owed much to Aristide Cavaillé-Coll (1811–1899), the greatest organ builder of his age, whose instrument Franck had at his disposal at St. Clotilde in Paris. Cavaillé-Coll pioneered a range of mechanical innovations. He specialized in making “symphonic organs,” which could mimic the sound of other instruments, such as the bassoon, the oboe, and the cor anglais. He introduced divided windchests and made refinements to the swell box and pedal systems, all of which helped the organ player produce an important new feature—a completely seamless crescendo from pianissimo to fortissimo.



CAVAILLE-COLL ORGAN, ST. SULPICE CHURCH, PARIS

Born in Liège in 1822, César Auguste Franck spent most of his career in France, although his family background was partly German. His father had a disappointing job as a bank clerk, sometimes unemployed, and transferred all his ambitions onto his children. So, when Franck and his younger brother showed early musical promise, they were swiftly enrolled at the Liège